populism dataset over others given its superior temporal and geographic coverage.

We employ ordinary least squares regressions, clustering standard errors at the country level and incorporating both country and year-fixed effects. To ensure robust results, we test a range of political and economic covariates that could also influence IMF participation. We include political characteristics, such as democracy scores (Polity2) and the political orientation of the executive (right-wing or not).[3] We also include international variables such as UN voting alignment with the United States, US aid receipts, and membership on the UN Security Council.[4] We then add economic indicators including per capita GDP, GDP growth, unemployment rates, and total debt service to GNI ratios.[5] We also control for institutional dynamics, including vote-power asymmetry at the IMF (Pratt 2021), capturing the gap between a country's economic power and formal IMF voting power. To address missing data, particularly for developing countries, we employ multiple imputation, a standard approach in recent IO studies (Schneider and Tobin 2020; Clark 2022).

The results, presented in table 3.1, align with our expectation: Populist leaders are significantly less likely to initiate IMF programs compared with nonpopulist leaders. The estimated effect size—approximately an 8 percentage point reduction in the likelihood of program participation—is both substantively and statistically significant. This aligns with our theory that populists avoid visible cooperation with IOs, even when doing so could address pressing economic needs.

We subjected our findings to several robustness checks, including binomial probit specifications, substituting country-fixed effects with random effects, and conducting sensitivity analysis by iteratively removing countries from the sample. In all cases, the results held firm (see Carnegie, Clark, and Kaya 2024).

These findings support our contention that populist leaders systematically withhold engagement from the IMF, even when economic circumstances might dictate otherwise. This reluctance underscores the broader antagonism that populists display toward IOs and the political risks they associate with visible cooperation. Having established this, we now turn to another populist strategy: manipulating the flow of information to IOs, with a focus on the World Bank.